

which was a popular mass protest to which many individuals and groups made their diverse contributions. But King's charismatic example both inspired activists to engage in civil disobedience and attracted the support of white liberals for the movement.

Relentless campaigning

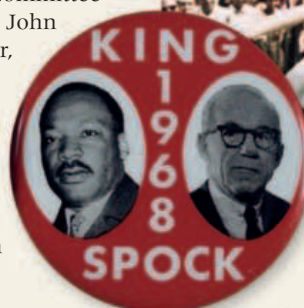
In the first half of the 1960s, King's influence was at its peak. He linked local direct action against segregation and for black voter registration in the southern states of the US to pressure at a national level for civil rights legislation. Many traditional black community and religious leaders felt King was too radical, for example, in backing the campaign of sit-ins at segregated lunch counters and other public facilities by the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) in 1960. President John F. Kennedy and his brother, Robert F. Kennedy, repeatedly urged him to moderate his position. But in 1963 King raised the campaign to a high pitch of intensity, encouraging confrontation between protesters and police in Birmingham, Alabama—confrontations that resulted in police violence that shocked world opinion—and mounting a “March on Washington” by around 250,000 demonstrators.

Outlawing discrimination

The passage of the Civil Rights Act in 1964, making many forms of discrimination illegal, and the Voting Rights Act the following year were the culmination of King's campaigning efforts. Awarded the Nobel Peace Prize, he stood at the height of his world fame. But at the same time his support among African-Americans was wavering. King's integrationist views—he wanted all races to have equal rights in a desegregated society—had always been

rejected by black separatists. Many young African-Americans also began to turn away from nonviolence, asserting the right to use force in self-defense. Young activists launched the aggressive slogan “Black Power,” while King appeared hesitant and indecisive.

From 1965 onward King grappled with causes and with his conscience. His attempt to establish contact with African-Americans in the ghettos of Chicago in 1966 was only partially successful. His outspoken opposition to US involvement in the Vietnam War



Running for US president
King had planned to run in the 1968 elections with anti-Vietnam War campaigner Dr. Benjamin Spock.

offended many African-Americans, who were proud of their sons' service in an integrated army. His shift away from rights and race to poverty was seen as controversially “socialist” in an American context.

Assassination in Memphis

The hatred provoked by King's views had always made him a target. He was under covert surveillance by the

“I have a dream...”

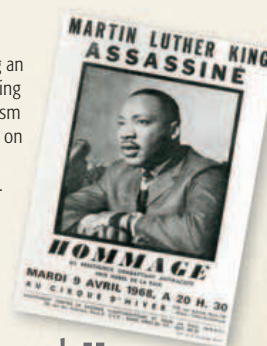
King salutes the crowd in front of the Lincoln Memorial during the “March on Washington” on August 28, 1963. This was the occasion for King's “I have a dream...” speech, arguably his most inspired and inspiring flight of oratory.

Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), whose head, J. Edgar Hoover, alleged that King was a communist and was trying to use evidence of his alleged sexual promiscuity to blackmail him. On April 4, 1968 King was shot dead on a balcony of a motel in Memphis, Tennessee. A petty

criminal, James Earl Ray, was convicted of the killing, though his guilt has been contested. King's death sparked rioting and arson in cities across the US: an ironic memorial to a man of nonviolence. His place in the pantheon of American heroes is now secure.

Homage to King

A poster advertising an event in honor of King by a French antiracism group, held in Paris on April 9, 1968, three days after his death.



“We, as a people, will get to the Promised Land.”

MARTIN LUTHER KING JR., SPEECH IN MEMPHIS, TENNESSEE, APRIL 3, 1968

US CIVIL RIGHTS CAMPAIGNER (1913–2005)

ROSA PARKS

Born Rosa McCauley, Rosa Parks was an active campaigner against sexism and racism from the 1930s. Her refusal to give up her seat to a white man on a segregated bus and her subsequent arrest in Montgomery, Alabama, on December 1, 1955 ignited the civil rights movement and the Montgomery Bus Boycott. Rosa Parks grew famous, but she was forced out of her job in a department store and left Alabama for Detroit, Michigan. She later became especially active in aiding black youths. In 1996, Parks was named the “Mother of the Modern Day Civil Rights Movement” by the US Congress.



TIMELINE

- January 15, 1929** Martin Luther King Jr. is born in Atlanta, Georgia, son of a Baptist pastor; the name entered on his birth certificate is Michael.
- 1948** Graduates from Morehouse College in Atlanta with a degree in sociology.
- 1951** Graduates from Crozer Theological Seminary in Chester, Pennsylvania, with a degree in divinity.
- June 18, 1953** Marries Coretta Scott.
- September 1954** Becomes pastor of Dexter Avenue Baptist Church, Montgomery, Alabama.
- June 5, 1955** Receives a PhD in theology from Boston University.
- December 1955** As head of the Montgomery Improvement Association, King becomes spokesman for the year-long Montgomery Bus Boycott protesting against segregation.
- January 30, 1956** A bomb explodes at King's home in Montgomery.
- November 13, 1956** The Supreme Court rules bus segregation illegal.
- January 11, 1957** King is elected head of the civil rights organization that will become the Southern Christian Leadership Conference.
- September 20, 1958** Stabbed by a woman during a book-signing in Blumstein's department store in Harlem, New York.
- 1959** Resigns as pastor at Dexter to focus on civil rights work; returns to Atlanta, Georgia.
- October 1960** King is imprisoned for participating in a sit-in protest in Atlanta, Georgia; presidential candidate John F. Kennedy contrives his release.
- 1961** Attorney-General Robert Kennedy asks the FBI to put King under surveillance.
- April 16, 1963** Imprisoned during civil rights protests in Birmingham, Alabama, King writes his “Letter from Birmingham Jail,” affirming the need to defy unjust laws.
- August 28, 1963** During the March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom, King delivers his “I have a dream...” speech from the steps of the Lincoln Memorial.
- July 2, 1964** Witnesses the signing of the Civil Rights Act, outlawing discrimination.
- December 10, 1964** At the age of 35, King becomes the youngest male recipient of the Nobel Peace Prize.
- March 7–25, 1965** King's leadership is rejected by younger activists.
- August 4, 1965** Voting Rights Act is passed.
- January 22, 1966** Moves into a tenement in a black ghetto in Chicago to draw attention to the issue of black urban poverty.
- April 4, 1967** Denounces the Vietnam War and describes the United States as “the greatest purveyor of violence in the world today.”
- April 4, 1968** King is assassinated at the Lorraine Motel in Memphis.



WINS NOBEL PRIZE 1964